

Living deserts

Every desert is a difficult habitat for the plants and animals living there. They have to cope with months without rain, extremes of temperature, sandstorms, and occasional flash floods. The animals must also find food, which is usually scarce. Most of the plants and animals living in the deserts of the world have similar ways of surviving, although some are unique.

Patagonian Desert

South America



Area 260,000 sq miles (670,000 sq km)
Annual rainfall 4–10 in (100–250 mm)
Average highest temperature 55°F (13°C)
Average lowest temperature 32°F (0°C)

The cold, dry highlands on the eastern flanks of the southern Andes are the home of tough desert shrubs and grasses. These provide food for ostrichlike rheas, pygmy armadillos, and llama-like guanacos. They are preyed on by foxes, pumas, and eagles.

Atacama Desert

South America



Area 40,600 sq miles (105,200 sq km)
Annual rainfall Less than 0.6 in (15 mm)
Average highest temperature 95°F (35°C)
Average lowest temperature -25°F (4°C)

Although it lies on the shores of the Pacific, this is the world's driest hot desert. A few cacti and other plants soak up the moisture carried in from the ocean by fog. Specialized brine shrimps survive on salt flats that flood after rare rainstorms.

Sahara Desert

North Africa



Area 3.5 million sq miles (9 million sq km)
Annual rainfall 0.8–4 in (20–100 mm)
Average highest temperature 100°F (38°C)
Average lowest temperature 32°F (0°C)

The world's largest hot desert stretches across 14 North African countries. It has a variety of landscapes, ranging from sand dunes to large areas of bare rock where

tough spiny shrubs grow. Watery oases (small areas of fertile land) are fringed by date palms. Animals include mice, foxes, snakes, and scorpions.

▼ DESERT WANDERER

Long-legged ostriches roam widely over the desert fringes. They can go without water for several days.

